When Sultan Khwaja came to Akbar with his milk brother's troubles – Shamsuddin Ataka's son, who hunted by Akbar's side in the great Lahore qamargah, who rode in Akbar's howdah against the Uzbek brothers, now besieged by the wretched Mirzas! – Akbar didn't hesitate.

The padishah had not been home three months when he left again. Perhaps he was driven by concern for Aziz, or for his new territories, or simply by rage at his relatives, but driven he certainly was – to a surge of strength and stamina so splendid that it has come to define the very essence of Akbar's conquering spirit.

~

Abul Fazl has the perfect metaphor for it: Akbar travelled as fast 'as Patience departs from lovers'.

Early on a Sunday morning, on 23 August 1573, Akbar mounted a she-camel, bow-necked, 'swifter than an arrow', and galloped west. Just over a week later, he reached Ahmedabad, having travelled a mind-numbing, body-breaking 900 kilometres in nine days.[45]

There were less than thirty men with him, including some who would become his closest friends or most trusted noblemen: Abdur Rahim, the orphaned son of Bairam Khan, not yet eighteen; Raja Birbar, a Brahmin poet recently introduced to Akbar's court. There were men of the Kachhwaha clan, too, though Akbar's brother-in-law, Bhagwant Das, had left a few days earlier so that he might proceed at a more leisurely pace with the harem, and Man Singh was still pursuing Rana Pratap in Mewar. And, in accordance with the Mughal family's obsession with record-keeping, there were painters, for the emperor was not only for acting for the moment, but also for the ages.

Good omens, too, accompanied the padishah. Akbar had begun, of late, to hunt for signs – quite literally. He would set a trained cheetah after a deer, declaring that if the predator struck and killed, so would the padishah. He did so now, and the cheetah didn't disappoint.

Some days later, the small group of men was lost in 'a forest full of mud'. Akbar was furious,[46] but it was here that he spotted his second omen: a lion appeared to their left. The men were keen to shoot it; Akbar loved hunting lions and perhaps they hoped a kill would improve his mood. But Akbar